

Power watch

The most common power-related PC problems originate from errant voltages. Hence, the best defence against voltage fluctuation is a good surge protector. It is always advisable to buy a good quality spike guard so that it can actually withstand any sort of fluctuation.

There are spike guards that also feature a resettable circuit breaker which lets one correct small interruptions with a quick flip of a switch instead of having to replace a fuse. Surge protectors with this feature often cost more but are worth it in the long run.



■ Many-a-times you might hear strange sounds coming out of the spike guard which might make you think that it's time to change it. Well, you are wrong. This sound simply means that the contacts need to be cleaned.

■ Make sure the power is switched off before cleaning the spike guard. Unplug all the attached peripherals and clean the contact with a dry, soft cloth.

■ If you are using an UPS, it is advisable to charge and discharge the battery once a month so as to extend its life. To do this, run the computer from the battery itself so that it gets completely discharged. Set the battery to charge again.



■ Never apply the solution directly on the scanner glass.
■ Do not unscrew the lid in order to clean it from inside if you find that the glass is dirty or has a slight dust or smoke film underneath. Call the authorised service centre and get them to do the needful.

■ Never use abrasives, Isopropyl alcohol, benzene, acetone, etc on the scanner glass. This will streak and cloud the glass and cause damage.

Printer

The worst part about a malfunctioning printer is that you usually find out the fault when the need is urgent. To avoid such situations, keep your printer well maintained. It's very easy actually and you needn't do much. Most problems are related to the ink which runs out and paper jams.



■ If you've installed the ink cartridges for the first time, remember that they need to be aligned. To do this, use the software that came along with the printer. All you have to do is click on the Align button and the cartridges will align automatically.

■ Store the cartridges in the right packaging; it makes sense to store extra cartridges in their factory-supplied containers. If you regularly switch between colour and black ink, store the swapped out cartridge in an old factory-supplied container or in a small zip-lock bag.



After cleaning your cartridges, make sure you place them back firmly in their slots

■ To avoid paper jams, clean the rollers inside by using alcohol. Do not forget to set your paper guides carefully and remember to never mix different types of paper in the same tray. Half the problems won't arise if you use the right paper.

■ Maintain the print head of your dot-matrix printer. Over a period of time, the metal contacts on the back of the print head may oxidise and lose their conductivity through exposure to

air. To clean it, you should use isopropyl alcohol and a lint-free swab.

■ For switching off the printer, use the printer's power switch rather than the switch on a surge protector.

■ Use the nozzle-clearing function (it blows ink through the nozzles to unclog them) if you have an inkjet printer. Use it regularly, especially if the printer lies unused for weeks at a stretch.

■ Spray a mild glass cleaner on a soft cloth and use it to wipe clean the outside of the printer.



■ If you spot a leakage, never open the inside parts of the printer. Always call the authorised service centre.

■ For optimal trouble-free performance, use the original ink cartridges, not the cheaper refilled ones from a local shop.

■ Avoid placing a bunch of papers in the tray without separating as this leads to paper jams.

Speakers

A good set of speakers would rarely give up on you, provided you use them reasonably. Being a music-lover doesn't necessarily mean blasting the speakers at the topmost decibel level.



■ Wipe the speakers using a soft cloth dampened with a mild detergent such as dish soap.

■ You can also lightly vacuum the grilles to remove the suspended dust particles.

■ If you are using an adapter other than the one that came along with your speaker set, match the ratings of the amplifier (RMS) and adapter (ohms), otherwise you could cause damage to your speakers.



■ Avoid listening to music at extreme volumes and reduce the volume level when a clear distortion is audible.

■ Never plug the speakers off while they are still on.

Ideally speaking, you should schedule operation cleanup for each of these peripheral devices every two weeks. If you are a very busy person (as we suspect), complete all these cleaning exercises at the first possible free weekend that you get.

Cleanliness pays off in the long run, you know that, so wipe that dirt off as soon as you can. It's your investment. Make it last more and enjoy a clean computing experience. ■

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